▶ MADHYA PRADESH

Electric Vigilantes

Stealing power from the neighbourhood line? Take care. Your neighbour may get rich!

By **Rahul Noronha**

CALL IT DECENTRALISATION OF POWER by other means. Like many public sector distribution companies in the country, the East Zone Power Distribution Company (EZPDC) of Madhya Pradesh has for long bled from losses. Or, again not atypically, been forced to fall back on government bailout packages to bankroll populist but fiscally imprudent decisions. But now it's come up with a novel way to reduce its aggregate technical and commercial (AT&C) losses. As a brainwave, it's surely the child of a voltage surge.

On July 1, the company rolled out an app-based reporting mechanism that keeps the whistleblower's identity anonymous. Its backronym, V-MITRA, is as spiffy as its full form is clunky: Mitigation of Irregularities Through Resource Audit.

Takeaways

- **MP discom hits upon a novel cure for power irregularities in state**
- **A reward scheme for citizen complainants lands a jackpot**

BUMPER RESPONSE

Its USP? As a first in India, those who report irregularities get rewarded directly—after due verification, of course. Other schemes pay out rewards only when bills or fine are paid by offenders. Developed in-house by EZPDC, the app also has provision for imposing a fine on staff in case they are found linked to the reported malfeasance.

The results have been striking. In the past 100 days, 30,000 complaints have flooded the app! Of these, 17,000 have been investigated. Against those numbers, the strike rate seems modest: only 4,000 complaints identified as genuine. But it's no zero sum game: a bill of Rs 5 crore has been raised against offenders; Rs 25 lakh recovered; rewards of Rs 15 lakh distributed. A particularly civic-minded individual has earned over Rs 50,000 by way of rewards. The company even had to deduct TDS from his earnings!

Overall, it's a jackpot. Earlier, vigilance teams received only an average of 50 complaints in a year. That's shot up to 300 a day. Lofty terms are being used for this citizen vigilantism, for which the company first geotagged all its 6.8 million consumers, spread over 25 districts. They're calling it an experiment in "participatory e-governance" and an "exercise in social audit".

Any citizen can register on the app via a mobile phone, generate an identity and share bank details (for the reward money). Eleven types of irregularities are listed, including plain-vanilla power theft and under-reporting of load (which enables subsidised billing). The complainant has to choose one, upload a photo of the site, and geotag the errant consumer by location or IVRS (interactive voice response system).

If found genuine, the reward—set at a 1:50 ratio with the billing amount—is paid in a week. To prevent frivolous complaints, the app allows only one complaint to be registered per IVRS in 15 days. A consumer wrongly targeted gets compensation. "We also rectify the root cause," says Anay Dwivedi, MD, EZPDC. "New connections are given immediately in cases of direct diversion of power. Weeding out non-genuine subsidy recipients leads to higher tariffs."

The company has also laid off some 2,000 outsourced staff for 'underperformance' and 'faulty meter reading'. You know what that means: they're now being retrained as whistleblowers! ■

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**